



DELHI | No Theme Parties

With the Lok Sabha elections barely two months away, both the Congress and BJP are finalising their poll campaigns even though both parties lack a charismatic leader and issues that can be hard sold to the electorate. For the Congress, the focus is on youth and reforms with a human face represented by the Rahul Gandhi-Manmohan Singh package. Or as a Congressman said, it's the John McCain-Sarah Palin combination, with Manmohan bringing in the experience and Rahul the zest. On the other side is L.K. Advani, an 81-year-old leader trying desperately to accessorise himself into a youthful icon to woo an electorate of a 100-million first-time voters. Like the Congress, the BJP is also running out of issues. It has been fighting state elections on the twin planks of economy and terrorism. But with declining inflation and a decisive home minister in P. Chidambaram, these seem to have lost their bite. Congress strategists point out there are around 120 urban constituencies where caste and religion do not matter as much as the cost of living and the economy. With the two national parties expected to peak at 150 seats each, the urban electorate could prove to be a crucial votebank for both. Yet, neither seems to have come up with a winning formula.

ADVANI AND
MANMOHAN
SINGH

120

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cies are
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by Priya Sahgal